StoryCast

Research and planning document. Ishimwe Sam Nelson, African Leadership University.
October 2026.

1. Project summary

StoryCast is a three-page accessible microsite that presents short audio and video stories. Every story is available as media, as captions where there is video, and as a full text transcript, so a visitor can use whichever format suits them.

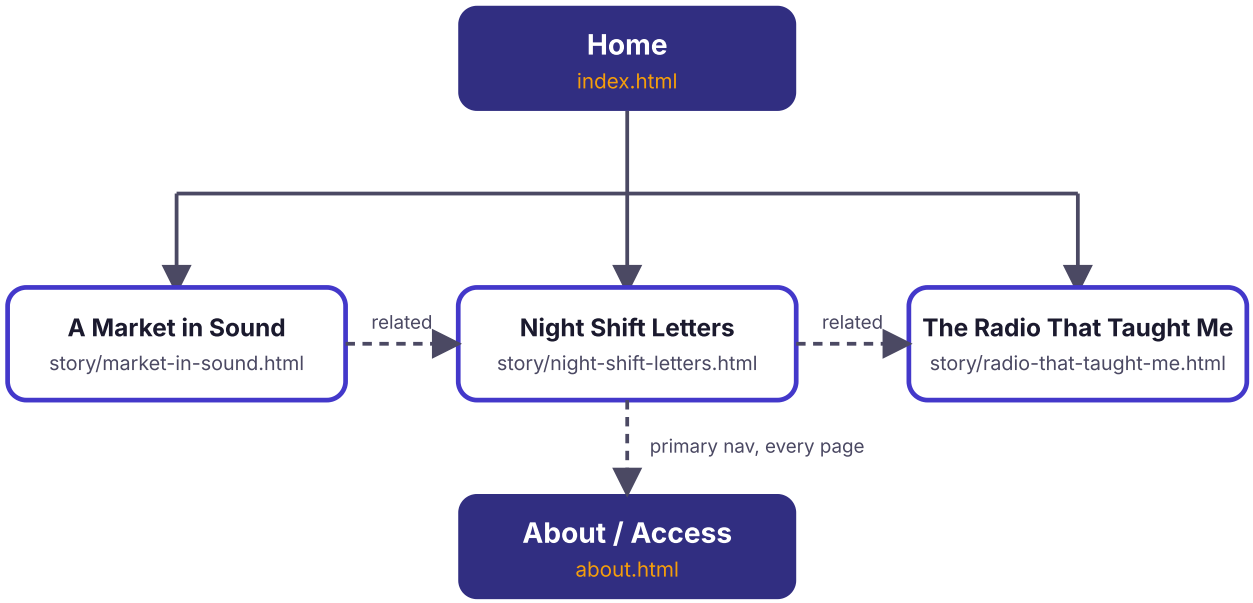
Who it is for

Visitor	Need	Design response
Deaf or hard of hearing	Understand speech without sound	Captions on by default, full transcripts, highlighted current line
Blind or low vision	Understand what is on screen, navigate by screen reader or zoom	Visual descriptions, landmarks, heading order, zoom-friendly layout
Keyboard-only or motor impaired	Operate everything without a mouse	Skip link, visible focus, large targets, real buttons for timestamps
Anyone on a phone or noisy place	Read instead of listen	Transcript on every story, downloadable as text

2. Information architecture

The site has three page types. Home is the entry point and leads to every story. A story detail page holds the media, transcript and related stories. The About / Access page explains the mission and access features. Primary navigation is present on every page, so no page is more than one click from another.

Sitemap



Solid lines are hierarchy from Home. Dashed lines are cross links: related stories link to each other, and the primary navigation on every page links to Home, the featured story and About / Access.

Page content plan

Page	Content, in order
Home	Skip link, header and navigation, hero with two calls to action, featured story cards (video, audio, audio), "every story, three ways" explanation, footer
Story detail	Breadcrumb, title and summary, media player in a figure with visual description, transcript with timestamps and download, story details, related stories, link to access features
About / Access	Mission, accessibility features, how to engage with a story, keyboard guide table, accessibility statement and known limitations, how to report a barrier

3. Wireframes

Wireframes (Figma): WIREFRAMES_LINK

Low-fidelity wireframes for Home, Story detail and About / Access, at desktop and mobile widths. They fix the content order and the reading order before any styling.

4. High-fidelity mockups

High-fidelity mockups (Figma): MOCKUPS_LINK

Digital mockups of the three pages showing final colour, type and layout, including the story card at its stacked and side-by-side sizes.

5. Design decisions

Decision	Reason
Deep indigo and amber palette on a pale paper background	Strong contrast: body text 15.7:1, links 7.29:1, amber on indigo 5.32:1. All meet WCAG 2.1 AA.
System font stack	Fast loading, familiar letterforms, and it respects the user's own font settings.
Transcript beside the media, not hidden	Reading is a first-class way to take in a story, not a fallback.
Story card uses a container query	The same card works in a wide column or a narrow one without depending on the screen width.
Native media controls	Browsers already provide accessible, keyboard-operable controls. Custom players risk losing that.

6. Standards followed

WCAG 2.1 level AA, semantic HTML5, WebVTT for captions, and progressive enhancement so the site works before JavaScript loads.